

UNREAL ENGINE 5 · THIRD PERSON · PC

THE COUNTY LINE

*A lawman simulation of jurisdiction,
paper, and consequence.*

Rivas County, West Texas · 1926–1928



DOCUMENT

Contents

01	<u>What this is</u> <i>One county. A job that can be taken away.</i>
02	<u>Pillars</u> <i>Jurisdiction, paper, four ledgers, no honor bar.</i>
03	<u>Engine & camera</u> <i>Unreal Engine 5, third person, PC.</i>
04	<u>Sam Reed</u> <i>Acting sheriff. Star on the coat or in a drawer.</i>
05	<u>The four ledgers</u> <i>Courthouse · Street · Capital · Home.</i>
06	<u>Cast</u> <i>Portraits, ages, heights, roles.</i>
07	<u>Story</u> <i>Three acts. No ending spoilers.</i>
08	<u>Map & locations</u> <i>Rivas County gazetteer locks.</i>
09	<u>Motor pool</u> <i>Official fleet and civilian traffic.</i>
10	<u>Animals</u> <i>What pays, what barks, what circles.</i>
11	<u>Systems</u> <i>HUD, reports, save, firing, accessibility.</i>
12	<u>Visual law</u> <i>Do / do-not. No RDR2 grammar.</i>
13	<u>Vertical slice</u> <i>What to build first.</i>
14	<u>Handoff</u> <i>Locked questions. Unreal work.</i>

Field	Lock
Title	The County Line
Setting	Rivas County, West Texas · 1926–1928
Genre	Third-person narrative open-world lawman simulation
Engine	Unreal Engine 5 (Lumen, Nanite, World Partition)
Platform	PC first · keyboard/mouse and controller
Classification	Locked canon · no ending spoilers
Revision	1 · 17 September 2026

01 · PREMISE

What this game is

The County Line is a third-person open-world narrative simulation. The player is Acting Sheriff Sam Reed. The job is not a mythic walkdown. It is paper, jurisdiction, weather, and who still drinks coffee with you after you sign a report.

The world is one dense county: Pecos Bend (brick courthouse town), Tanner Lease (oil to the west), River Road (farms along the Rivas River), and Open Range. Travel takes time. Caliche fails in rain. There is no menu fast travel. Promotion and firing are public. After a firing at 5:00 p.m. game time, Reed can remain in the county as a civilian — the rebel path — without the star, the county sedan, or the jail keys.

Tone is bureaucratic 1920s realism. Prohibition exists as a basement economy, not a tommy-gun fantasy. Combat is rare, ugly, and expensive on every ledger. The verbs that matter are serve paper, write a report, knock, wait, testify, and drive.

02 · DESIGN

Pillars

- Jurisdiction is gameplay. County, lease, river families, and later federal letterhead do not share a map color. Crossing a line changes who can fire you.
- Paper outranks the gun. Reports are assembled from known facts the player includes or omits. The Enterprise prints what is signed, or holds it.
- Four ledgers, no honor meter. Courthouse, Street, Capital, Home. Thresholds stay hidden. Clerks remark when you cross one.
- The star comes off. Firing is a world state. Pruitt is painted on the door. Reed keeps a pocket compass and a rented room.
- One county, not a mythic West. Brick, telephone poles, oil derricks, wool coats, motors under fictional badges.
- Time is a resource. Weather and road state change travel. Waiting is a verb.

03 · TECHNICAL

Engine, camera, platform

Item	Lock
Engine	Unreal Engine 5 — Lumen, Nanite, World Partition. Unity only for UI / journal prototypes.
Camera	Third-person over-the-shoulder. Visible protagonist. Documentary lenses, not heroic longs.
Platform	PC first. Keyboard and mouse, and controller.
Lighting	Practical noon, overcast, electric interiors. No golden-hour hero walks.
Audio	No score on the HUD. Ford, wind, bell, telephone, typewriter. Source radio only.
Traversal	Walk, County 1, livery, mule, Vines's cycle, hired horse. No mythic cross-map sprint.
Length	Dense campaign. High-20s to 30+ hours if the player works the county.

04 · PROTAGONIST

Who Reed is



Acting Sheriff Sam Reed

Age 44 · 178 cm · he/him · default player

Appointed after Hal Voss resigned “for his health.” Lives at Mrs. Lang’s until the job or the firing says otherwise. Writes in short sentences. Not a myth. The star is on the coat or in a drawer. UI copy: “Reed” in journals; “Sheriff” while DutyState = OnDuty; “Mr. Reed” after firing. Subtitle tag: REED.

Reed is the only playable body in the slice. After Terminate, county property is revoked at 5:00 p.m. that game day: sedan, jail keys, star widget, reserved Court Street parking, the right to answer the telephone as Sheriff. He keeps a cheap pocket compass and civilian clothes. The coupe is the fired-path car.

05 · SYSTEMS AS FACTIONS

The four ledgers

There is no honor bar. Consequences live in four opposing columns. Numbers stay hidden. When a threshold is crossed, Inez or a clerk remarks: “Whitlock asked about the budget again.”

Ledger	What it is	Who moves it
Courthouse	Minutes, payroll, the door with the name on it	Helm, Padilla, Pruitt
Street	Who still takes coffee, River Road, the square	Salazar, Lang, Quintana, River Road
Capital	Oil, budget, the car, scrip	Whitlock, Tanner, camp physician
Home	Hours at the table, letters, sleep, Lang’s room	Lang, Reed’s own time

Commissioner weights (locked): Whitlock = Capital + Payroll. Salazar = Street. Helm never breaks a tie. On Terminate: DutyState becomes Fired; sign repaint; Pruitt promoted acting. Vines can quit if Street or Courthouse collapse. Voss still moves all four over time. Do not treat him as a boss fight.

Courthouse



Judge Helm

Age 61 · 175 cm · Courthouse

Wants a clean minutes book more than a true one. His office window faces the square. He will not break a tie between commissioners. Promotion and firing pass through his gavel.



Inez Padilla

Age 38 · 162 cm · County Clerk

Paper, stamps, and the typed copy of Reed's journal if accessibility is on (diegetic "clerk's typed copy"). She sees every report before the judge does.



Commissioner Whitlock

Age 54 · 180 cm · Capital + Payroll

Oil, budget, the car. The man who asks about money. His sedan is too clean for the county. Scratching it is a Capital event. He is a ledger, not a cartoon.



Commissioner Salazar

Age 49 · 173 cm · Street

River Road and the square's working families. Who still drinks coffee with you. He hears the camps when Whitlock does not want to.

The office



Deputy Earl Vines

Age 29 · 185 cm · The deputy who shows up

Not comic relief. Can quit if Street or Courthouse collapse. Often on the county cycle along fence lines when the ruts beat a sedan.



Deputy Pruitt

Age 34 · 176 cm · Waiting

Pressed uniform. A smile that does not always reach the eyes. If Reed is fired at 5:00 p.m., Pruitt is the name they paint on the door.



Hal Voss

Age 58 · 174 cm · Former sheriff

Resigned for his health. Still has a section on the Open Range. People use his name like weather. No badge. Do not schedule him as a duel.

Town



Mrs. Lang

Age 56 · 160 cm · Boarding house · Home

Bed, table, save point ("Write the date"). She will still have a room if the star comes off. That is not the same as loyalty.



Doc Ellison

Age 52 · 170 cm · Town physician

Town, not lease. The ambulance answers to him. A body from the ditch — he writes a different sentence than the camp physician.



Mara Holt

Age 31 · 168 cm · The Enterprise

Signed versus held. She prints what Reed puts on paper, or she holds it. The newspaper is a system, not flavor text.



Rosa Quintana

Age 36 · 165 cm · Bend Hotel kitchen

Dining room is legal. The door behind her is Act II. Vertical slice: kitchen + open door + one conversation.

Lease and later



Tanner

Age 47 · 182 cm · Tanner Lease · Capital

Easement, scrip, quiet. Capital lives in a railcar office. He needs the grade finished and the minutes clean.



Camp physician

Age 41 · 177 cm · Tanner Lease

Unnamed on the wall map. His signature closes cases the courthouse would rather not reopen. Compromised professional, not a slasher.



The federal man

Age 45 · 179 cm · Act III

Letterhead. He does not care about local custom. Arrives late. Do not put him on the title screen.

Unnamed on purpose: the Act I ditch family, section-gang labor, the ranch split on Open Range. They should look like the county, not a boss cast.

07 · NARRATIVE

Story — no spoilers

Reed is acting sheriff in a county that has already chosen oil and has not finished choosing what that costs. Voss is gone. The star is temporary until the commissioners make it permanent — or take it back.

Act I — The ditch

A body on the Bend Lateral. Paper versus talk. River Road wants a name. The lease wants a natural cause. The first hour teaches serve, write, drive, and wait. Cottonwood Crossing is the south river ford and the painted county-line post — not a State Line tourist sign.

Act II — The grade

Pipeline and fence. Camps, scrip, a strike that Salazar hears and Whitlock does not want. The hotel kitchen door becomes a place you can enter. Reports accumulate. The Enterprise starts choosing.

Act III — Letterhead

Someone from outside the minutes book arrives. Local custom stops being enough. Promotion, a permanent star, a public firing, or a life without the badge — all remain possible. Endings are consequences already in the ledgers, not a cutscene wheel.

This bible does not name the dead of Act I, does not say why Voss left, and does not say what is behind the kitchen door. Those are play.

08 · WORLD

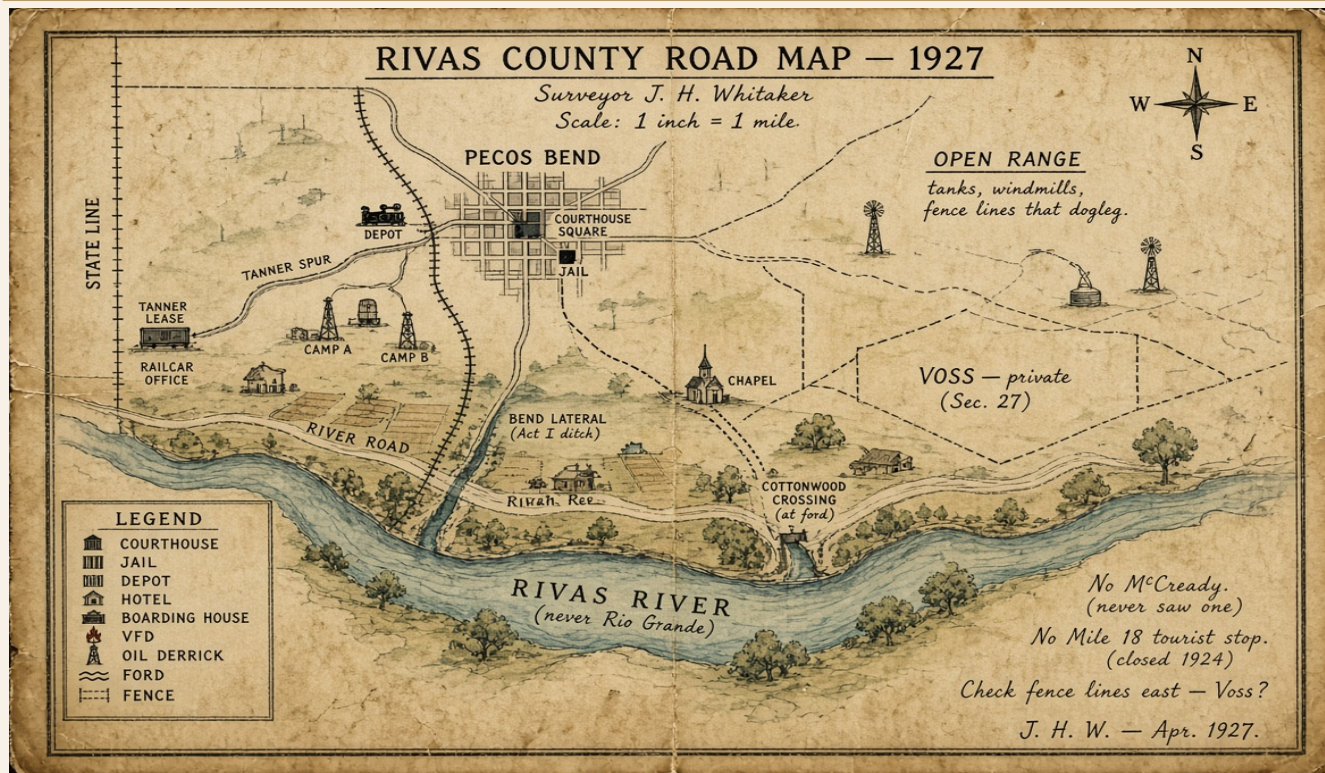
Map and locations

Two sheets. The town map is street scale: buildings, alleys, the depot on the west rail. The county map is road scale: winding caliche, Tanner Spur, River Road, Cottonwood Crossing, Bend Lateral. Pink cells on older plats were blocks, not houses. The railroad never cuts the square.



Pecos Bend, street scale. Courthouse in the square. Jail north. Hotel and Enterprise on Court Street. Lang's northeast. Depot and Tanner Spur on the west edge. River Road starts south of town.

County roads



Rivas County road map, 1927. Tanner Lease west. Open Range and Voss east. Rivas River along the south. Bend Lateral is the Act I ditch. Cottonwood Crossing is a ford, not a state line.

District	What you find	Notes
Pecos Bend	Brick courthouse, jail, Lang's, hotel, Enterprise, VFD, depot, square	Hub. Electric lights. Paper.
Tanner Lease	Camps, derricks, railcar office, scrip store, tank batteries	Capital. Easement law.
River Road	Farms, older deeds, chapel across the water, irrigation	Street. Spanish in kitchens.
Open Range	Tanks, windmills, fence, Voss's section	Cattle, cut wire, pipeline grade.
Cottonwood Crossing	Shallow ford, cottonwoods, painted county-line post	Not a state-line postcard.
Bend Lateral	Irrigation ditch off the river road	Act I. Buzzards if you are late.

Gazetteer locks

- Delete any "McCready" sign or ranch invented by tools.
- Mile markers follow county roads. Do not invent a Mile 18 tourist pull-off.
- State Line is off the playable county. The painted post at Cottonwood Crossing is a county line.
- Dynamic: pipeline progress, new fence, sign repaint after firing, camp strike state.

09 · VEHICLES

Motor pool and civilian traffic

House makes only: Hallett-Briggs, Austin-Ward, Crowell, Redlake, Ward. No Ford script on a grille. No 1950s cruiser. No modern lightbar.



County 1 — possessable while OnDuty. Lost at 5:00 p.m. the day Reed is fired. Overheats on wet caliche.



Engine 1 — Pecos Bend VFD chemical pumper. Ride the running board; do not own it.

Call name	User	Role
County 1	Reed on duty	Possessable sedan. Revoked on firing.
Engine 1	Pecos Bend VFD	Lease fires, Act II grade. Not a toy.
County ambulance	Doc Ellison	Stretcher + bag. Crowell coach body.
Lease hauler	Tanner Camp A	Scrip world. Blocking one is Capital.
The coupe	Reed after firing	Rebel car. No roof lamp.
Livery touring	Bend Livery	Hire when County 1 is dead.
County cycle	Vines (sometimes Reed)	Fence lines and River Road ruts.
Depot wagon	SP & TP Express	Evidence, mail, Act III trunk.

Civilian traffic — required

If only County 1 and Engine 1 move, the town is a museum. Everyday cars are world traffic. Reed does not collect them.

Call name	Flavor	Notes
Court Street sedan	Mercantile, Holt, church	Two parked on the square is enough.
River Road truck	Farms	Milk cans, wire. Blocks a ford.
Commissioner car	Whitlock (Tanner cousin)	Too clean. Do not let Reed keep it.
Buckboard	Anyone without a motor	Still the default on Open Range.
Horses / livery	Town and range	Half the county still rides.

Animals

Horses are the ride. Everything else should pay the bills, make a noise, or tell you someone died. This is not a hunting game.



Open Range cattle — brands, gates, “natural” deaths. Street versus Capital.



Jail-yard mule — freight and refusal. Outlasts County 1 in gumbo.

Animal	Priority	Job
Cattle	Must	Open Range economy. Fence war. Lease “natural” carcasses.
Mules	Must	Work animal. Jail wagon, pump station, refusal at the ditch.
Dogs	Must	Alarm and witness. One named dog at Lang’s or the jail.
Chickens	Must	Dawn noise. Town texture.
Buzzards	Must	Look-here marker over ditch, lease, any body.
Sheep	Should	River Road wool. Quieter money than beef.
Goats / pigs	Should	Brush lots; one pen, one complaint in the minutes.
Jackrabbits	Should	Bolt on caliche. Not loot.
Coyotes	Should	Heard at night. Ranchers will ask you to “do something.”
Rattlesnakes	Should	Ditch and pipe hazard. Doctor visit. No snake-boss.
Pronghorn / mule deer	Should	Sparse glimpse. Not a safari.
Javelina, quail, hawks, owls	Texture	Audio first. Night and brush.
Cats, dairy cow, pigeons, flies	Town only	Lang’s, hotel, courthouse eaves.

Leave out: bison herds, wolf packs as regular fauna, legendary hunt targets, fishing skill trees, exotic camp zoos.

11 · RULES

Systems lock

HUD

Diegetic-leaning. Compass tick is Reed's own pocket compass and survives firing. What dies with the job: county sedan, jail keys, star widget, "Sheriff" on the telephone, reserved parking. States: OnDuty, InFord, Fired. No numeric ledger meters.

Reports

Known facts only. No free-text field. The player toggles discovered facts (include / omit). Omitting a known fact feeds Cases and The Enterprise (signed vs held). Reed may pick one closing sentence from three authored lines.

Save

Only at desks and beds: jail desk, Lang's table, hotel night clerk, fired rented room. Action: "Write the date." No save-anywhere.

Accessibility

Journal default may be handwritten. Settings toggle: "Clerk's typed copy" — Inez Padilla's carbon. Same words. Required, not polish.

Combat and Prohibition

Guns exist. Shootouts are rare and costly on every ledger. Hotel basement is Act II; v-slice is the kitchen doorway only. No tommy-gun fantasy.

First hour

Wake at Lang's. Walk to the jail. County 1. A call about the Bend Lateral. Serve, look, drive back, write a report from known facts. Talk to Padilla. No basement. No federal man.

12 · LOOK

Visual direction

Do

- 1926–28 lock: wool coats, campaign hats, brick, poles, derricks.
- Shorter lenses, over-the-shoulder, visible body language.
- Noon, overcast, practical lamps. Dust as weather.
- Paper, brass, stamps, carbon copy as chrome.

Do not

- Dusters, false-front saloons, high-noon duels, sunset walks.
- Empty desert-highway hero poses.
- Modern lightbars, 1950s cruisers, Ford trademarks.
- Honor meters, wanted-star carnivals, legendary animals.

13 · BUILD

Vertical slice

Locations. Jail office (night), Court Street approach, Lang's table, Bend Lateral / Cottonwood Crossing bank, hotel kitchen doorway, one oil-camp street at noon.

On camera. Reed, Padilla, Vines, Lang, Rosa (doorway), one River Road face, one lease face.

Systems. DutyState, journal with four ledgers (hidden numbers), fact-toggle report, Write the date, County 1 with weather modifier, compass that survives a debug firing.

14 · HANDOFF

Production notes

Do not reopen the eight locked questions: default name Sam Reed he/him; compass stays; reports are facts-only; ledger numbers hidden; basement is Act II; save only at desks; no score; typed-copy toggle required.

Suggested Unreal work: spring-arm camera, journal widget, ledger subsystem, DutyState + Fired world state (sign painter, Pruitt on the door, County 1 lock), weather/caliche travel multiplier, interaction verbs (serve, knock, write).

Art naming: 01_reed through 15_federal for portraits; vehicle call names as above; animals as cattle / mule / buzzard / sheep proxies plus audio. Map river label in-engine: RIVAS RIVER.

End of locked bible. Endings live in the ledgers. Do not print them here.